

tional background music was composed by Graeme Revell (*Sin City* and *Pineapple Express*). The two movies, says Reliance Big Pictures CEO Sanjeev Lamba, have the "same soul, but different beats", as the team gets ready for premieres at the West End Odeon in London and the AMC on 42nd Street in New York.

Perhaps delving into the classics is a way of escaping the lunatic fringe which tends to hijack moviemaking today. Witness the protests in Tamil Nadu over the suggestion that *Raavan* could be premiered at a film event in Colombo. What began as a simple request from Jha to writer Anjum Rajabali in 2004, that he work on a script on electoral politics culminated over seven days and seven nights of drinks and conversation into a decision to base it on generic characters. "I'm besotted with the Mahabharata, so I was delighted not to reflect any actual characters," says Rajabali, who gave Jha the first draft in November 2004. Indeed, viewers will find many resonances but not just with the Mahabharata, whether it is Kaif's character, the widow who steps into power; Kapoor, the reluctant outsider who challenges every rule; or Patekar, the mentor who counsels courage under fire.

For Jha, working with a talented ensemble cast was a joy as much as it was a discovery—whether it was

SUMMER LOVING



BARBARA MORI
AND HRITHIK
ROSHAN

KITES

A Rs 130-crore buy for Reliance, it is expected to be Bollywood's biggest release yet, across 2,300 screens worldwide, starring Hrithik Roshan in skin-on-skin with Mexican TV actor Barbara Mori. Mori, coolest mother of a 12-year-old, calls it a "love story one can feel in any part of the world". *Hmm. The world waits.*

I HATE LUV STORIES

A Rs 18-crore purchase for UTV from Dharma Productions, it has been picked up for satellite viewing for Rs 10 crore. A romantic comedy directed by

Manish Malhotra's nephew Punit, it features Imran Khan as the boy who would be a man. It was the first film to begin its publicity with Twitter.

SONAM
KAPOOR
AND IMRAN
KHAN



From being self-consciously modern, Hindi cinema has become confident enough to adapt Indian cultural texts to contemporary narratives.

Kapoor's prep ("he's been acting for four generations so if he prepared it was not visible to me"), Kaif's commitment ("she had her dialogues recorded on her phone and once wanted to recompense me for a day's shooting lost because she hadn't learnt her lines") or even Arjun Rampal's energy ("as Bhim, he had to be aggressive and full of energy, very different from the introspective characters he's played recently"). Some scenes had 7,000 extras from Satna, Gwalior and Hoshangabad, who needed continuous workshops over nine months, and

60 buses to be ferried for the 7 a.m. call sheet. Almost as big a cast had to be assembled to fulfil Mani's ambitious storytelling, from Govinda as Hanuman to Nikhil Dwivedi as Lakshman. Plus underwater scenes, snakes, leeches and actors leaping to and from trees. Action director Sham Kaushal had nights without end for the 200-day shoot across Kerala, Maharashtra, and Madhya Pradesh, where Hindi and Tamil scenes were shot back-to-back, with the talented Tamil actor Vikram playing Ram in the Hindi version and *Raavan* in the Tamil cut.

By the time the shoot ended, he'd become an expert at "putting on and taking off make-up".

It's a summer where India will meet Bharat, where politics will provide entertainment, where the literary texts, or so Bollywood hopes, will translate into literal money, and yes, where Katrina Kaif will be administered the Jan Shakti Party oath. In a summer where a minister has lost his job thanks to a tweet and another minister's phone conversations have been after-dinner idle chatter, even that can become reality. ■